

How to Spot a **Freight Scam** & Stop It.

A simple handbook, in plain English, for the people who book loads, vet carriers, handle papers, and send payments. Real cases. Real numbers. Clear steps.



\$725M stolen in 2025

· +60% losses vs 2024

· \$2.8B lost to email scams

Sources: Verisk CargoNet · FBI IC3

What this book is

This handbook teaches one skill: how to tell a **real** partner from a **pretender**. That is what almost every freight scam comes down to.

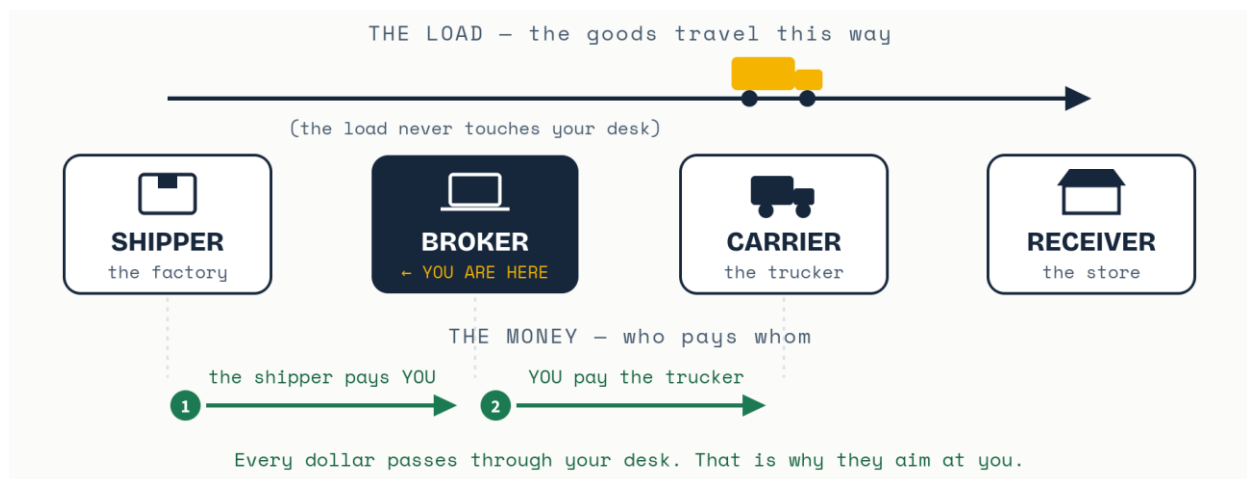
A scam, in one line: A stranger pretends to be someone you trust — a trucker, a broker, your own boss — so you hand over money or cargo before you notice. Your job is to catch the pretender before you click “send.”

We will go in order. First the **Big Three** scams (the ones that steal the most). Then **every other type**, explained in one breath each. Then a map of **where** the chain breaks, the **numbers** that prove this is real, and finally your **daily shield** — a checklist you can keep on your desk.

CHAPTER 1 · THE LAY OF THE LAND

Why scammers love the BPO desk

Freight moves through a chain: a shipper hands goods to a broker, the broker finds a carrier (the trucker), and the carrier delivers to the receiver. The back-office BPO desk often sits in the middle — booking carriers, checking papers, and moving payments.



The load goes past you (factory → store), but the money goes through you: the shipper pays you, then you pay the trucker. That is why your desk is the target.

That middle seat is exactly why it is a target. The desk holds three things a scammer wants:

- **The money.** It releases payments and can change bank details.
- **The logins.** Load boards, email, and the carrier database all live here.
- **The “yes.”** It makes the decision to trust a new carrier.

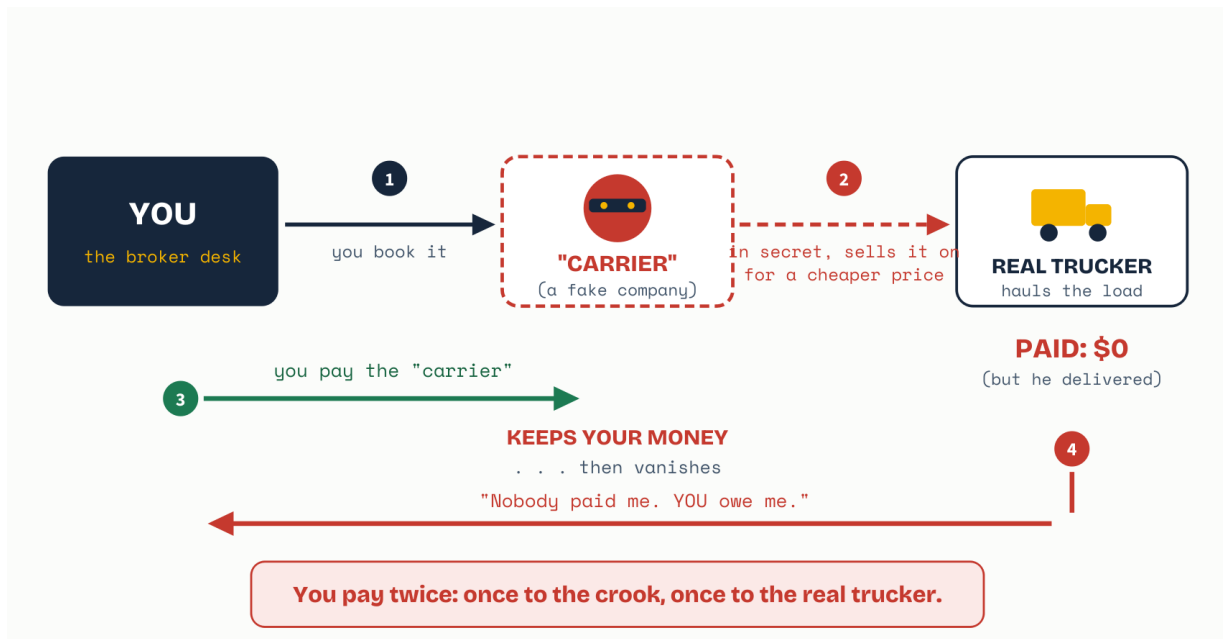
Control all three and a scammer barely needs to hack anything. So this book keeps coming back to one habit: **verify the people on the other side, every time.**

The three scams that steal the most

If you learn only this chapter, you will already block most of the money lost to freight fraud. Each one is the same trick wearing a different mask.

No. 1 — Double Brokering

a.k.a. “secretly passing the load to a stranger”



Follow the numbers: you book a “carrier” (1), who secretly sells your load on to a real trucker (2), takes your money and vanishes (3) — then the unpaid real trucker comes to you (4). You pay twice.

HOW IT WORKS

1. A “carrier” books your load and promises to haul it.
2. Instead of driving it, they secretly hand it to a different, real trucker at a lower price.
3. You pay the booked “carrier.” They keep the money and vanish.
4. The real trucker delivered the goods but is never paid — and now wants your company to pay again.

STOP IT

- ✓ **Forbid re-brokering in writing** in your rate confirmation.
- ✓ Confirm the truck that *actually* shows up matches the carrier you booked.
- ✓ Get the **driver’s name, the truck and trailer number, and a pickup photo**.
- ✓ If the carrier “subcontracts,” or the driver doesn’t match the paperwork — **freeze the payment and verify** before anyone gets paid.

CASE FILE · double brokering + identity theft

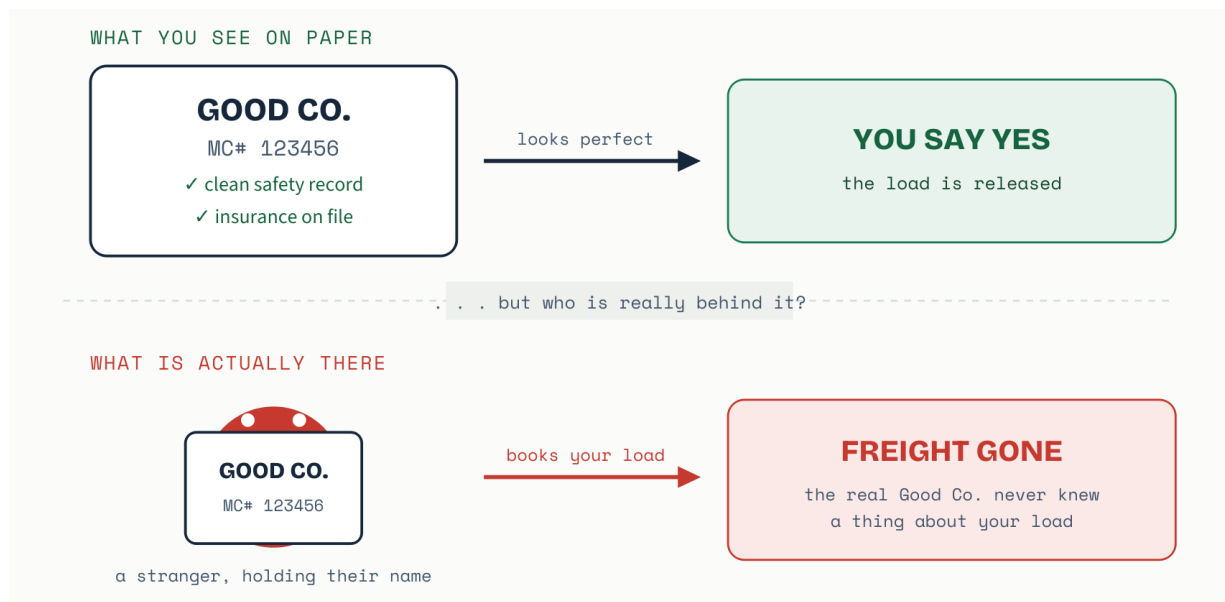
CONVICTED

A man ran the scheme from Tijuana, Mexico. He stole the identity of a real California trucking company, agreed to haul loads under that stolen name, then re-brokered the same loads to other truckers. He collected the delivery payments and never paid the truckers who actually moved the freight. He was arrested abroad, extradited to the United States, pleaded guilty, and agreed to pay restitution.

Restitution owed to victims: at least \$239,904. — U.S. DOJ (via Overdrive)

No. 2 — Identity Theft & Impersonation

a.k.a. “wearing a real company’s name like a mask”



Top: the clean paperwork you see — a real company, a real MC number. Bottom: the stranger holding that same name up like a mask. Same number, different person.

HOW IT WORKS

1. Crooks take the name, MC/DOT number, or login of a real, trusted company.
2. They change the contact details on file (phone, email, insurance) so replies come to them.
3. Wearing that trusted identity, they book loads — and steal the freight or the payment.
4. The real company’s good name takes the blame.

STOP IT

- ✓ **Don’t trust a name or number alone.**
- ✓ Call the carrier back on a number *you* looked up in official records — **never the number in the email.**
- ✓ Watch for fresh changes to contact info or insurance, brand-new authority, and mailbox-only addresses.
- ✓ A familiar logo is not proof — **verify the human on the other end.**

CASE FILE · strategic theft

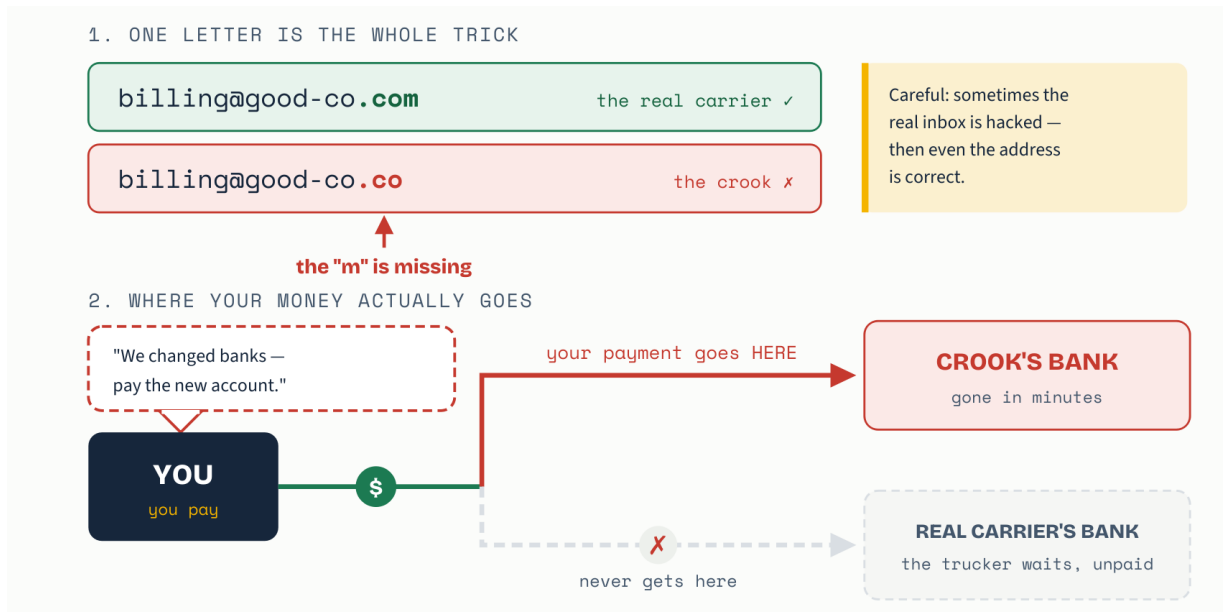
FBI ALERT

In 2025 the FBI warned that criminals are increasingly using stolen company identities and hacked accounts to steal whole truckloads — changing a carrier’s contact and insurance information, posting tens of thousands of fake loads, and spoofing real companies with look-alike domains and free email. Their advice: verify on more than one channel, turn on multi-factor logins, and photograph the driver and truck at pickup.

— FBI IC3 Public Service Announcement

No. 3 — Business Email Compromise (BEC) & Phishing

a.k.a. "the fake email that reroutes your money"



One letter is the trap: good-co.com is real, good-co.co is the crook. The e-mail says "we changed banks" — so your payment lands in their account and the real trucker is never paid.

HOW IT WORKS

1. A scammer gets into — or copies — a real email account you trust.
2. They email you a "small update": new bank details, a new payment portal, an urgent invoice.
3. The look-alike address is one letter off, so it sails past a quick glance.
4. You pay, or share a login — straight to the criminal.

STOP IT

- ✓ **Never change bank details from an email alone.**
- ✓ Call the known contact on a saved number and confirm out loud.
- ✓ Read the sender's full address **letter by letter**.
- ✓ Turn on **two-step login (MFA)** for email.
- ✓ Treat any "urgent + secret + new account" message as a red flag until a second person confirms.
- ✓ When money is involved, **slow down on purpose**.

CASE FILE · email fraud

\$2.8B / YEAR

Business email compromise is one of the costliest scams online — about \$2.8 billion reported lost in a single year, and roughly \$8.5 billion over three years, across tens of thousands of complaints. Almost all of it comes down to one trick: a trusted email asking you to move money, or to change where it goes.

— FBI IC3

Every other scam, in one breath each

Most of these are cousins of the Big Three. For each one: what it is, the tell (the warning sign), and how to stop it.

Mask scams — fake identities

Crooks pretend to be a company that exists, or invent one that looks real.

Phantom & “chameleon” carriers A fake trucking company that doesn’t really operate — or a banned one that reopens under a brand-new name to hide its past. Red flag: Brand-new authority, no real history, a mailbox address, a story that keeps changing. Stop: Check the age of the authority and a real, verifiable office; be extra careful with “new” carriers.	Fictitious (fake) pickup A driver shows up with the right-looking paperwork, takes the real load, and is never seen again. Red flag: Driver or truck don’t match the booking; rushed or odd pickup; you can’t verify the dispatcher. Stop: Verify the driver and truck against your booking, and photograph everything at pickup.
Forged paperwork Fake or edited Bills of Lading, delivery receipts (PODs), or rate confirmations made to look official. Red flag: Logos slightly off, copy-pasted signatures, numbers that don’t match your system. Stop: Match every document to your own records; confirm details with the known source, not the document.	Stolen broker identity Crooks pretend to be a well-known broker (not just a carrier) to book trucks and run double-brokering at scale. Red flag: “Broker” uses free email, off-brand domains, and pressure to skip your normal checks. Stop: Confirm the broker through official records and a known number before you commit a truck.
FMCSA record tampering Crooks quietly change a real carrier’s phone, email, or insurance in the official FMCSA database, so your verification calls and payments reach them — not the real company. Red flag: Contact details on file changed recently; the number you call “confirms” everything a little too smoothly. Stop: Don’t trust one record — cross-check against an older source, watch for recent changes, and confirm on a second known channel.	

Money scams — getting paid for nothing

The goal is cash now — advances, fake invoices, or disappearing before the bill comes due.

Fuel-advance fraud A “carrier” books a load just to grab the upfront fuel advance, then never hauls it. Red flag: Asks for an advance fast, weak history, goes quiet after payment. Stop: Limit advances for new carriers; release money only after pickup is verified.	Non-payment / vanishing After delivery the booking party disappears and never pays the people who did the work. Red flag: New relationship, vague contacts, excuses when payment is due. Stop: Vet who you work with, get terms in writing, and watch first deals closely.
POD (proof-of-delivery) fraud	Surprise / hidden charges Extra fees and made-up accessorial charges piled on after the fact.

Fake or altered delivery proof used to trigger payment for a load that wasn't delivered as claimed.

Red flag: POD looks edited, times don't line up, the receiver can't confirm.

Stop: Confirm delivery with the receiver before releasing final payment; don't pay on a POD alone.

Red flag: Charges that weren't in the agreement, vague descriptions, pressure to pay quick.

Stop: Match every charge to the signed agreement; question anything new.

Computer scams — breaking into your systems

These hit the BPO desk hardest: one password or inbox is the key to everything.

Account takeover

A criminal gets into your email, load-board, or TMS account and acts as you.

Red flag: Logins you don't recognise, changed settings, contacts updated without you.

Stop: Turn on two-step (MFA), use unique passwords, and review account changes.

Load-board credential hack

Stolen load-board logins are used to post fake loads or grab real ones under your name.

Red flag: Posts you didn't make, new devices, complaints from people you never contacted.

Stop: Protect those logins like cash; enable MFA; remove access fast when staff leave.

Phishing, smishing & quishing

Scam messages by email, text, or fake QR code that trick you into typing a password or opening malware — disguised as a "dispute," "new form," or "account alert."

Red flag: Pressure to act now, odd links or QR codes, login pages that look slightly wrong.

Stop: Don't click links or scan QR codes in surprise messages; type the website yourself or use a saved bookmark.

Offshore shared-access leak

Shared logins across an outsourced team mean one leak exposes every account.

Red flag: One password for many people, no record of who did what, access never removed.

Stop: Give each person their own account; log actions; remove access the day someone leaves.

People scams — tricking the human

The newest and oldest trick: skip the computers, fool the person.

Social engineering

A smooth talker uses urgency, authority, or friendliness to push you past your normal checks.

Red flag: "Do it now," "keep this quiet," "your boss approved it" — pressure instead of proof.

Stop: Pressure is the red flag. Pause, verify on a known channel, and it's always okay to say "let me confirm."

AI-powered fraud (emerging)

Crooks now use AI to write flawless scam emails and to fake a familiar voice — or even video — to "prove" they are your boss or a known carrier.

Red flag: A trusted voice or a polished email suddenly asking for money or a load change; pressure to act now.

Stop: A voice or a perfect email is not proof anymore. Confirm big requests with a code word or a second known channel.

Road & cargo scams — stealing the freight itself

Here the target is the physical load — taken on the road, at the dock, or by someone on the inside.

Cargo hostage / extortion

Once a crook controls your load, they refuse to deliver and demand a ransom to reveal where the truck and goods are.

Red flag: The load goes silent after pickup, then a sudden demand for extra money to release it.

Fake inspection / fake tow

Someone poses as a DOT inspector, police officer, or tow service and demands instant payment for a made-up fine or towing bill.

Red flag: On-the-spot cash demand, pressure to pay now, paperwork or ID that can't be verified.

Stop: Vet carriers up front, track the load, and never pay a ransom alone — escalate, document, and involve security and law enforcement.

“Trojan driver” (insider)

A gang member gets hired as a real driver, works normally for a while, then leaves a loaded truck somewhere for accomplices to steal.

Red flag: A new driver targets high-value loads, makes odd route choices, or leaves a truck in a strange spot.

Stop: Screen and background-check drivers, watch high-value loads closely, and use tracking and check-in rules.

Stop: Real fines and tows can be verified — slow down, confirm with the official agency, and never pay strangers on the spot.

Pilferage / document swap

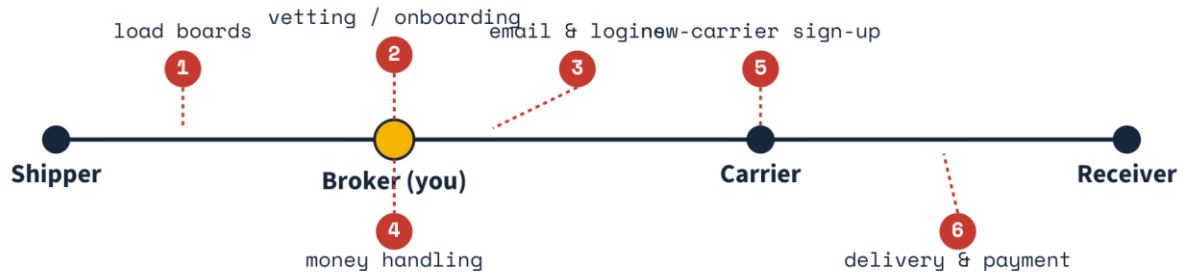
Small amounts are stolen from a shipment and the paperwork is quietly altered to hide that anything is missing.

Red flag: Counts don’t match the paperwork, edited or re-printed documents, seals that look tampered with.

Stop: Count and seal at pickup and delivery, match every figure to your own records, and flag any altered document.

The weak seams to guard

The whole industry guards the front door — booking the load. So crooks now sneak in downstream: after the load is booked, at delivery, and at payment. These are the six seams where fraud slips in.



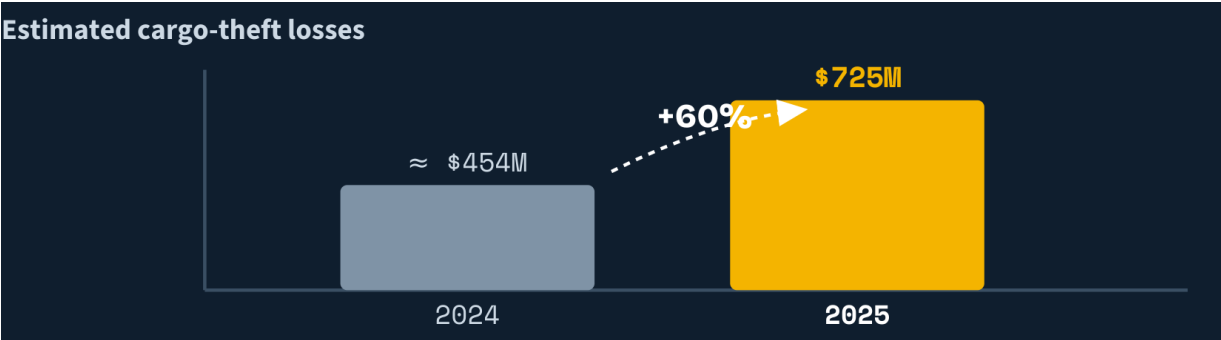
The whole industry guards the front door — booking the load. So crooks sneak in downstream: after the load is booked, at delivery and payment. The red points are the six weak seams.

- **Load boards.** Where loads and trucks meet — and where fake loads and stolen logins flood in.
- **Vetting & onboarding.** The moment you decide to trust a new carrier. Weak checks here let masks through.
- **Email & logins.** One hacked inbox or shared password turns a crook into a trusted insider.
- **Money handling.** Changing bank details or paying advances — the exact step BEC scams aim for.
- **New-carrier sign-up.** Fake or mailbox-only addresses let phantom and chameleon carriers be born.
- **Delivery & payment.** Fake PODs and double-broker tricks bite right at the end, when guards are down.

This is real, and it is growing

A few numbers to keep you alert. Each one is from a named source, so you can trust it.

\$725M Estimated cargo-theft losses in 2025 — up 60% from 2024. Verisk CargoNet	2,646 Confirmed cargo thefts in 2025 — up 18% from 2,243 the year before. Verisk CargoNet	\$273,990 Average value of a single theft in 2025 — up 36%. Verisk CargoNet
\$2.8B Lost to business-email-compromise scams in one year (~\$8.5B over three). FBI IC3	~1/3 Share of cargo theft now done by “deception” — up from under 5% a few years ago. Industry trackers	~400% Reported rise in double-brokering complaints across the industry. Industry reporting



Estimated cargo-theft losses rose about 60% in one year — roughly \$454M in 2024 to about \$725M in 2025 (Verisk CargoNet).

An honest note about numbers. Nobody has a perfect, government-stamped count of every fraud in the chain. The U.S. regulator (FMCSA) even told Congress it lacks the data to fully measure double brokering. The strongest figures come from private trackers (like Verisk CargoNet) and the FBI. So treat these as the best estimates we have — directionally true and clearly rising — not exact totals.

The fixes, all in one place

If a handbook could be one habit, it is this one: **Stop · Check · Go**. Use it on every load, every payment, and every odd request.

STOP	CHECK	GO
When something is urgent, secret, or “too good,” pause. Speed is the scammer’s best friend — slow down on purpose.	Verify on a channel you chose: a phone number you looked up, official records, a second person. Never the contact in the suspicious message.	Only after it checks out, release the load or the money. Then write down what you did, in case you need a trail.

The desk checklist

Tick these for every new carrier, every payment change, and every pickup.

- **Call back on a number you found yourself.** Use official records — never the number written in the email or load post.
- **Check the carrier’s authority and history.** Be extra careful with brand-new authority, sudden contact or insurance changes, or a “carrier for sale.”
- **Reject mailbox-only addresses.** A real, verifiable place of business matters; virtual or PO-box “offices” are a warning sign.
- **Read the email address letter by letter.** Watch for look-alikes (.co vs .com) and free email pretending to be a company.
- **Two people for any money or bank change.** Confirm new bank details by voice on a known number before paying a cent.
- **Never click links or download “forms” from surprise emails.** Type the website yourself or use a saved bookmark.
- **Photograph the pickup.** Driver, licence, truck and trailer numbers, plate, and the paperwork — and check they match your booking.
- **Forbid re-brokering in writing,** and confirm the delivering driver is the carrier you actually hired.
- **Confirm delivery with the receiver** before you release the final payment. Don’t pay on a POD alone.
- **Lock your logins.** Turn on two-step (MFA), use unique passwords and your own account only, and remove access when people leave.
- **Treat a familiar voice with care.** Voices can be faked — confirm big asks with a code word or a second channel.
- **When in doubt, escalate.** It is always okay to say “let me confirm and call you back.” A real partner will wait.

Red-flag cheat sheet — pause if you see these

- › “Urgent — do it right now.”
- › Brand-new bank details by email.
- › Brand-new authority, no history.
- › Email address one letter off.
- › Pushes you to skip your checks.
- › Strange links or “dispute” forms.
- › “Keep this between us.”
- › Rate or price that’s too good.
- › Office is just a mailbox.
- › Free email for a “company.”
- › Driver or truck doesn’t match booking.
- › Phone number that keeps changing.

Verify before you trust

The single habit that stops most scams: look the company up **yourself**, on a website you typed — never a link they sent you. Here is exactly how, and where.

The 6-step carrier & broker check

1. Get their **legal company name** and their **USDOT or MC number**.
2. Look that number up **yourself** on FMCSA SAFER — type safer.fmcsa.dot.gov into your browser. Don't use a link they sent.
3. Confirm the **operating authority is ACTIVE** and the **insurance is on file** (FMCSA L&I — li-public.fmcsa.dot.gov).
4. Check the **phone and email** against the official record. If the number they gave you doesn't match, call the number **SAFER lists** instead.
5. Treat **recently-changed contact info** — or **no phone shown in SAFER** — as a red flag, and don't book until you confirm another way.
6. Only then book the load — and **photograph the driver, licence, truck, plate, and paperwork** at pickup.

FMCSA's own warning: even insurance certificates can be faked, and the top results in a web search can be fake profiles set up by scammers. Confirm names and numbers on more than one trusted source.

Where to check & where to report

✓ Check a carrier or broker — free & official

FMCSA SAFER — look up any carrier or broker by USDOT/MC number and see if their authority is active. safer.fmcsa.dot.gov

FMCSA Licensing & Insurance (L&I) — confirm operating authority and that insurance is on file. li-public.fmcsa.dot.gov

Report fraud — free & official

FBI IC3 — report online and cyber-enabled fraud, BEC, and stolen identity. ic3.gov

FMCSA NCCDB — report bad brokers and carriers and freight fraud (now has a freight-broker category). nccdb.fmcsa.dot.gov

FTC — report scams and identity theft. reportfraud.ftc.gov

USDOT Inspector General Hotline — fraud involving DOT programs.

oig.dot.gov/hotline · phone **1-800-424-9071**

Helpful lines: FMCSA Contact Center **1-800-832-5660** · NCCDB hotline **1-888-368-7238**

Going further: does the truck actually exist?

The free tools above check a carrier's *paperwork* — their authority, insurance, and record. But a crook can have clean paperwork and still own **no trucks at all**. A newer kind of tool checks the carrier in the **real world**.

GenLogs is one example. It runs a nationwide network of roadside cameras and sensors that read the **USDOT number, plate, and logo** on passing trucks — about **15 million truck sightings a day** — and uses AI to match a carrier's real movements against what they claim on paper. (Its cameras ignore private cars and blur windows, so they only read commercial-truck markings.)

For a back-office desk, that kind of **physical verification** helps you:

- ✓ **Catch a “carrier” that exists only on paper** — one with no trucks actually on the road, which is the tell-tale sign of double brokering.
- ✓ **Confirm a carrier is real and active**, running the right equipment, before you hand over a load.
- ✓ **Find a stolen or missing trailer** — GenLogs offers a free service where carriers, brokers, or shippers submit a missing asset and get its last-known location and live alerts.
- ✓ **Expose “chameleon” carriers** — in the Indiana case in Chapter 8, an investigator used GenLogs to show AJ Partners was still hauling freight after its fatal crash.

Worth knowing: GenLogs is a paid commercial service (not a free government tool like SAFER), and it covers U.S. roads. Use it as an **extra layer** on top of the free checks — not a replacement. genlogs.io

If you think you’ve been scammed — do this now

1. **Stop the payment.** Call your bank straight away and try to halt any pending transfer.
2. **Save everything.** Emails, phone numbers, documents, screenshots, and the load and booking details.
3. **Report it.** FBI IC3 (ic3.gov), FMCSA NCCDB (nccdb.fmcsa.dot.gov), and the FTC (reportfraud.ftc.gov).
4. **If your company’s identity was used**, correct your contact details in SAFER and tell your insurer, your load boards, and your factoring company.
5. **Warn people.** Tell the real company being impersonated, and alert your own team so no one else falls for it.

This is really happening

Every scam in this book is real. Here are four cases you can look up yourself — with names, dates, and dollars, and a link to the official source or news report for each.

CASE FILE · carrier-impersonation ring (New York)

Charged · 2026

In June 2026, the Manhattan District Attorney charged eight people who ran a cargo-theft ring across the Northeast. Working with hacking groups that **phished shipment details**, they **impersonated real trucking companies**, won the loads with the stolen information, then arrived in trucks marked with the real carrier's name and drove the freight away. Across six thefts (October 2025–April 2026) they took goods worth about **\$4.49 million** — lamb, beef, roughly 25,000 pounds of cheese, copper, and cigarettes — and sold them on the black market. In one pickup a driver posing as **Viking Transport** collected 43,100 pounds of copper rod from a Newark warehouse. The cargo owners and the real carriers whose names were used had no idea until the goods were gone; cargo-theft analytics firm **Verisk CargoNet** assisted the investigation.

~\$4.49M stolen · 8 people charged · case IND-71638-26 — Manhattan D.A.

Sources: Manhattan D.A. — manhattanda.org · FreightWaves — freightwaves.com · Gothamist — gothamist.com

CASE FILE · the deepfake video call (Arup)

2024

In January 2024, a finance worker at the Hong Kong office of **Arup** — the global engineering firm behind the Sydney Opera House — received an email from the “CFO” asking for a secret transfer. He was suspicious, so he joined a **video call** to check. On the call he saw and heard the CFO and several colleagues — but every one of them was an **AI deepfake**. Convinced, he made **15 transfers totaling about \$25.6 million** (HK\$200 million). He only realised it was fake after calling head office, and the money was never recovered. The lesson the whole industry took from it: **a familiar face and voice are no longer proof**.

~\$25.6M lost · 15 transfers · deepfake CFO + colleagues — Hong Kong Police / Arup

Sources: CNN Business — cnn.com · Fortune — fortune.com · World Economic Forum — weforum.org

CASE FILE · a “chameleon” carrier network (Indiana)

2026

In February 2026, a truck crash in **Jay County, Indiana** killed four people. Investigators found the carrier, **AJ Partners**, was part of a “**chameleon**” network — companies that pile up violations, get shut down, then reopen the next day under a new name and a fresh DOT number to wipe the slate clean. The FMCSA put AJ Partners and four affiliated carriers (**KG Line Group, Tutash Express, RPM Hauling, and Valcins Trucking**) out of service; the driver had been “trained” by a **sham CDL school**. Government auditors (the U.S. GAO) have found these reincarnated carriers are about **three times more likely** to be in serious crashes. That is why a brand-new authority with no track record deserves a second look.

4 killed · 5 carriers put out of service · ~3× crash risk — FMCSA / U.S. GAO

Sources: Overdrive — overdriveonline.com · FreightWaves — freightwaves.com · U.S. GAO (chameleon-carrier study)

CASE FILE · double brokering (FTC v. Apex)

2018

Double brokering isn't new. In 2018 the U.S. **Federal Trade Commission** took action against a California freight broker, **Apex Freight Services**, that took payment from shippers but never

delivered the loads or paid the carriers who hauled them. The broker **settled for \$500,000**. It's the same trick that fills complaint lines today: reported double-brokering complaints jumped about **400%** between late 2022 and early 2023.

\$500,000 settlement · ~400% rise in complaints (2022-2023) — FTC / industry reporting

Sources: Grant Thornton (case summary) — [grantthornton.com](https://www.grantthornton.com) · U.S. FTC — [ftc.gov](https://www.ftc.gov)

A real partner will always wait

Pressure to skip a step **is** the scam. Slow down, verify on your own channel, and you turn the BPO desk from the weakest point into the strongest lock on the chain. Every check you make protects a real trucker, your company, and your own good name.

SOURCES

Verisk CargoNet 2024–2025 cargo-theft analyses; FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) reports and 2026 public service announcement on cyber-enabled cargo theft; FMCSA Broker & Carrier Fraud guidance and the SAFER / L&I / NCCDB tools; U.S. Government Accountability Office (GAO) study on “chameleon” carriers; and industry reporting (Truckstop, TIA) on the ~400% rise in double-brokering complaints.

GenLogs — freight “Truck Intelligence” platform (roadside-sensor network + AI for physical carrier verification, fraud and cargo-theft prevention, and asset recovery): genlogs.io · ccjdigital.com

CASES CITED IN CHAPTER 8

Carrier-impersonation ring, New York (2026) — Manhattan D.A. (case IND-71638-26): manhattanda.org · freightwaves.com

Arup deepfake video-call fraud (2024) — Hong Kong Police; Arup: cnn.com · weforum.org

“Chameleon” carrier network, Indiana (2026) — FMCSA / U.S. DOT: overdriveonline.com

FTC v. Apex Freight Services (2018) — double brokering; \$500,000 settlement: grantthornton.com

DISCLAIMER

This handbook is general educational guidance for awareness and training — not legal, financial, or insurance advice. Court cases described here are based on public announcements and news reporting; charges are allegations and defendants are presumed innocent unless proven guilty. Always follow your company’s own policies and verification procedures. Figures reflect the latest available reporting as of mid-2026 and may be updated by their sources.